UNITED GRAND LODGE OF ENGLAND

BUILDING TOGETHER

Attracting Members – Growing Freemasonry

SUPREME GRAND CHAPTER OF ROYAL ARCH MASONS OF ENGLAND



BUILDING TOGETHER

Digital Quick start guide

V1 MAY 2025

THE MEMBERSHIP CHALLENGE

In recent years Freemasonry has unfortunately been losing more members than it has been gaining and **The Membership Challenge**, which every Unit is asked to address, is essentially to reverse that trend. It is an intrinsic part of the Strategy for 2022 and beyond.

Although you might see figures referring to the size of the Challenge at UGLE / SGC level, or Provincial level, it is your individual Unit figures which are the most relevant to define what actions will be needed at Unit level.

Your Unit records or even Provincial records can provide the membership statistics for the previous 5+ years, which will show how many members have been lost and how many new members have joined – whether the trend is positive or negative.

When considering how to close the gap between gains and losses, the most reasonable and practical approach would be to increase the gains and at the same time reduce the losses.

This will require determined effort over time, involving all members, arranging events to attract new members, finding ways to involve every member in the life of the Unit to increase their sense of belonging, interest and commitment, and being alert to the early signs of poor attendance or late payment of dues, ready to step in to offer support and encouragement as appropriate.





ENGAGE

Supporting the New Member

Developing Understanding

From their first meeting, the new Brother or Companion is presented with a huge amount of information.

They will want to make sense of this and learn at their own pace and in their own way about the organisation they have joined. While a lot of written and video material is available to them, it is important that they can be guided through it by a Personal Mentor who understands their interests as an individual and the priorities of their Lodge.

Liaise with your Provincial Membership Team regarding the use and availability of any such materials and ensure the materials are not just ‘dumped on’ the new member but are explained. Don’t overwhelm him with too much information.

Signpost the new Brother / Companion to the Solomon resource and demonstrate how to navigate the site and get the most from it.

Unit rehearsal meetings are an important part of the Understanding process as it is generally a more relaxed environment for questions to be asked.

Thread Link: Developing Understanding

CLICK PDF icon to download the support material

- Simple Explanation of the Initiation Ceremony
- Welcome Companion Narrative
- Explanation Chapter Officers





ENGAGE

Supporting the New Member

Encouraging Participation

Units that conduct good ceremonial and ritual, have vibrant festive boards and have a social element outside of meetings tend to be the most successful Units regarding membership.

Participation can be split into three areas:

1. Meeting attendance:

- Ensure they know the dates
- Discuss timing of attendance before the meeting
- Meet them well ahead of any meetings to run through any signs, movements etc
- Discuss their progression within the Unit
- Encourage them to deliver pieces of ritual
- Designate someone to accompany them out of the meeting if they have to retire for any reason.

2. Visiting other units:

- Explain the protocol of visiting and inviting
- Take them to see an initiation at another Unit
- Encourage them to invite masonic guests to meetings.

3. Unit social events:

- Encourage their attendance
- Explain that they can invite friends, family etc (if applicable)
- Get them involved in the events.

Provincial Grand Lodges also have many special interest Units and numerous different clubs that will enhance a members' enjoyment of his Freemasonry. Liaise with your Provincial Membership Team to find out more.

Thread Link: Encouraging Participation



ENGAGE

Supporting the New Member

- Planned Mentoring

The new Brother or Companions has just entered a new world and requires assistance to guide them while they take the initial steps on their masonic journey.

This can be achieved by appointing a member of the Unit to take on this responsibility acting as their Personal Mentor.

Thought also needs to be given as to who is best suited to undertake this important role.

Think back to when you joined your first Lodge or Chapter; what could you do to help him?

Thread Link: Planned Mentoring

Regular contact

Familiarise them with the venue and rooms within it

Explain what is happening and why



Introduce him to the members of the Unit

Ensure that he is not left alone at meetings or practice

Guide him through masonic protocols and traditions of the Unit.



ENGAGE

Continued Support

Fostering Fun, Enjoyment and Satisfaction

Freemasonry should be fun and exciting, throughout your masonic journey regardless of time served.

Members who are happy with their Unit and who are comfortable and satisfied as Freemasons will attract visitors and new members.

Light Blues Clubs are a fantastic addition to a new member's experience. With Past Masters' Lodges, Past Principals' Chapter, Provincial and Grand Officers' Mess a great way to continue fostering fun, enjoyment, satisfaction and learning.

Provinces will have many various clubs and special interest Units that may interest, especially for the new Brother / Companion looking to make their first visits.

Any new member may need some assistance and encouragement to look beyond activities taking place at the Unit level. Social media, websites and internal communications are important avenues to be explored by new members.

Thread Link: **Fostering Fun, Enjoyment and Satisfaction**

CLICK PDF icon to download the support material

PDF Getting More Out of The Royal Arch

PDF Readings During Exaltations and Installation



ENGAGE

Continued Support

Guiding a Member's Learning

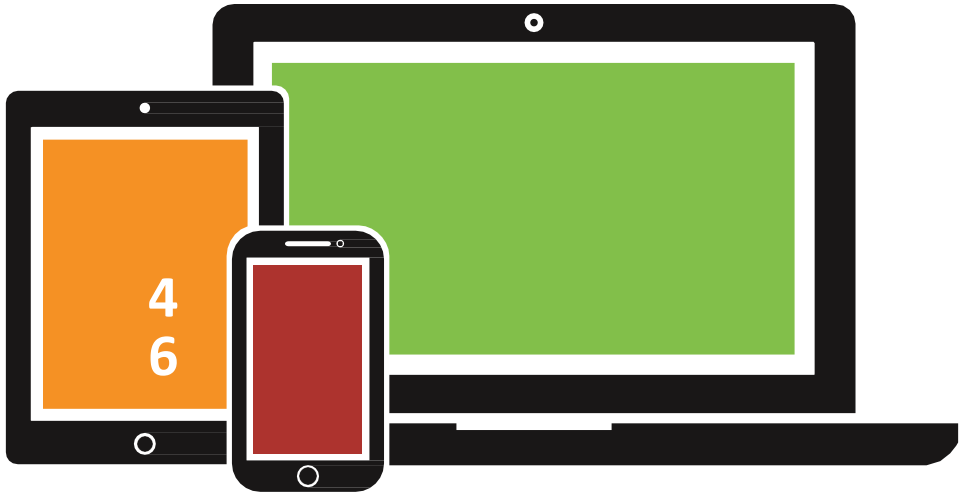
Learning about Freemasonry, developing an understanding of it and taking part is central to our enjoyment of it. New members in particular (Brethren and Companions) have a need for new learning and these needs fall into two parts.

The first is what Freemasonry wants or expects them to learn, so that they can participate.

The second is what they wish to learn about Freemasonry, to satisfy their own interests and motives for joining.

Experienced members also find that at different times in their membership they need to learn new things, especially as they approach the chair, become a Past Master (or PZ), take on continuing office in a Unit and, perhaps, become Metropolitan / Provincial / District or Grand Officers.

The Thread gives guidance for Units, to help them guide a new and existing member's learning in those aspects that Freemasonry wants or expects them to learn. In addition to guidance on different approaches to learning styles depending on an individual's needs (see learning for Conditions support material).



Guidance on unit Protocol:

- How to wear Regalia correctly
- How to give the signs, tokens and words
- Addressing members of the Lodge / Chapter and guests
- Fire at the festive board
- Visiting.

IN CRAFT:

Preparation for Passing and Raising:

- Questions and answers, support and practice
- Correct regalia and options for purchase.

At a Meeting :

- Sit with them
- Explain process
- Voting/balloting.

Undertaking Ritual:

- Discuss with them – no pressure!
- Provide positive encouragement
- Time to practise.

Thread Link: Guiding a Member's Learning

CLICK PDF icon to download the support material

Learning for Conditions

Involve Learning Ritual



ENGAGE

Continued Support

Supporting Personal Learning

It is important to discuss with the new and junior member how he would prefer to access information with regards to learning.

Learning Can Be Undertaken By:

- Personal research
- Supplied reading
- Books
- Websites
- Discussion
- Online resources – UGLE webinars, Solomon Live, etc.

Solomon online is a superb repository for learning and new members should be encouraged to register. **The Lodge of Instruction** (LOI) / **Chapter of Improvement** (COI) should also be considered the foundation for any learning that the new member undertakes. What is most important is that new and junior members are allowed to set the pace of any development so that it remains an enjoyable part of their discovery of Freemasonry.

More detail can be found in the full thread:

Thread Link: Supporting Personal Learning







ENGAGE

Continued Support

Helping a Member Relocate

Migration is the process of assisting members find a new Unit when they relocate across Provincial boundaries or abroad. Its purpose is to help members find new Units well suited to them and to enable them to continue their membership without a break in service. Achieving this purpose involves three elements.

First, through active mentoring and engagement, Unit Officers should be aware of a change in any member's circumstances. PRE-MIGRATION encourages engagement with members to anticipate and support any changes in circumstances, such as decorating ready to move or interviewing for a new job.

Secondly, with the awareness of a member's plan to relocate, Secretaries / ScribeE / Mentors, with the consent of the Member, should complete UGLE's Migration form. Completion of this migration form triggers the

Thirdly, where a receiving Province's membership team will contact the migrating member and support him in finding a new masonic home without breaking their membership.

Supporting a member to Migrate

When discussing migration with a member, be sure to present them with fair and impartial advice; remember that if a member is to move whilst they may be a loss to your Unit, it would be a great shame for them also to be a loss to Freemasonry and who knows they may occasionally visit! www.ugle.org.uk/migration

Thread Link: Helping a Member to Relocate



ENGAGE

Continued Support

Continuing Your Journey

BUILDING TOGETHER is introducing the approach which encourages brethren to set the expectation of a prospective member that they are joining Freemasonry not just a Craft Lodge.

At the point of Initiation, Passing and Raising the brother receives further explanation as to the context of their journey. *This can be supported by the optional Contextual Narratives, which are not ritual but explanations which will aid a Brother's understanding at key stages of their journey. To learn more about these resources please speak to your Provincial Team*.

Having become a Master Mason the Brother is now able to continue their journey of understanding and join the Royal Arch. The traditional Lodge Member tasked with this duty is the Lodge Royal Arch Rep and whilst their contribution is invaluable in promoting the Royal Arch **The Lodge Mentor** and a Brother's Personal Mentor are the individuals who are best placed to discuss with the Brother the commitment, time and associated costs joining the Royal Arch has – by doing this they will be able to facilitate an introduction to the **Best Chapter for The Member** which may not be the one traditionally associated with the Lodge. However it is more important that we keep a future companion engaged by placing them in a Chapter which meets on a day, location and time that best works for them, than we do maintain a tradition feeding just to one Chapter and subsequently lose the member.

The full thread reviews this subject in greater detail and is suggested reading for all Companions who should be champions of the Royal Arch.

Thread Link: **Continuing Your Journey**



ENGAGE

Re-engaging inactive members

Tracking attendance and apologies

Tracking attendance and apologies is a vital tool to indicate the health and viability of your Unit.

Resignations are often preceded by periods of absence, relative to the individual's normal pattern of attendance. Therefore, a break in pattern and diminishing attendance is a warning sign of possible issues, whether they relate to reduced interest, dissatisfaction or a change of personal circumstances. It makes sense for Units to monitor individual attendance, and to make enquiries if absences vary or increase from their normal pattern.

How this is done varies depending on if your Province uses Hermes, so please visit the thread which details a number of approaches depending on the tools you have available.

Thread Link: Tracking Attendance





ENGAGE

Re-engaging inactive members

Recognising Signs of Dissatisfaction

The reality is Freemasonry isn't for everyone, however good screening and expectation management can reduce this being an issue. Sometimes we have to face the reality that membership may not be right for the individual however efforts should be undertaken to establish if membership of a particular Unit isn't right for the individual or membership as a whole is and issue, common reasons include:

1. Difficulty attending because the Unit does not suit work or family circumstances.
2. Disappointment or dissatisfaction.
3. Difficulties with another member or members.
4. Changes in circumstances such as age, transport, health, family, employment, or financial issues.

When this is the case one of the following warning signs may have been demonstrated and members are encouraged to be on the look out for the following:



Thread Link: Recognising Signs of Dissatisfaction



ENGAGE

Re-engaging inactive members

Engaging with Absent Members

Members who don't attend meetings, fail to give apologies and are perhaps in arrears with fees could be considered 'already lost' to a Unit.

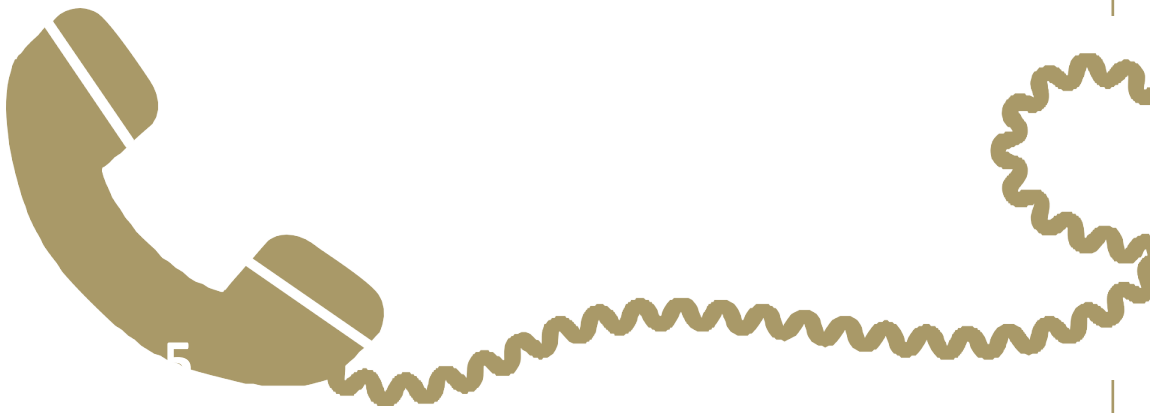
If your Lodge / Chapter is following the good practice outlines in 'Tracking attendance and apologies' hopefully you will not have a member in the situation described above, however should you find
you do the following are points to consider:

- Who in the Unit has the best relationship with the member, do they speak / meet with them outside of meetings and are they willing to have a discussion with them?

If no one has a pre-existing relationship with the absent member contact your Provincial Retrieval Team which will then be able to reach out to the absent member and act as a neutral party.

Full guidance on how to engage with non attending members is found in the full thread here:

Thread Link: **Engaging with non-attending members**





RESPOND

Poor Engagement

Connecting with Unattached Members

Once a Freemason has resigned from all of their Lodges / Chapters, they are termed "unattached" and there are rules governing his rights to visit other Lodges / Chapters.

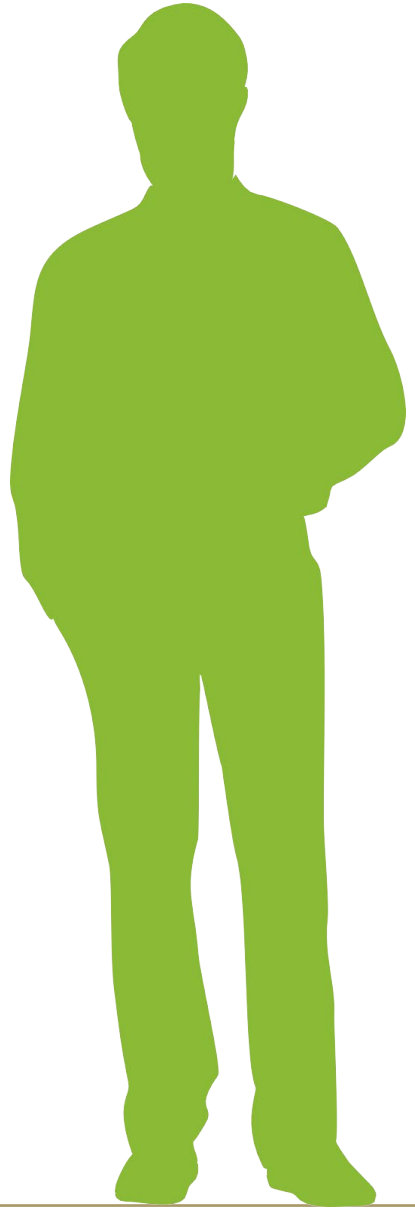
Contact with unattached freemasons should be done with the consent of a former member. Should an individual contact a Unit stating that they are an unattached Freemasons and they are not known to members enquiries should made via the Provincial Office before engaging with the Unit.

Further guidance on connecting with unattached members is contained within the full thread accompanied by a list of the rules and regulations governing unattached masons.

Thread Link: Connecting with Unattached Members

CLICK PDF icon to download the support material

PDF Rules Governing Unattached Masons





RESPOND

Poor Engagement

Resignations & Next Steps

Freemasons who resign from a Unit are often reluctant to disclose to members of the same Unit their full REAL reasons for doing so. However, understanding the real reasons for a resignation is essential if you and your **Unit Membership Team** are to make your Unit more attractive and improve your management of membership matters.

This is because:

1. Unless you understand why a member really resigned, you are unlikely to be able to correct the issue and retain their membership.
2. Without knowing why people resign from your Unit, you are unlikely to prevent the issue from recurring in future.
3. Therefore, understanding the real reasons members resign helps you to correct issues and prevent them from happening again.

GUIDANCE FOR UNITS AND PROVINCIAL TEAMS is listed in detail in the full thread.

Thread Link: Resignation & Next Steps

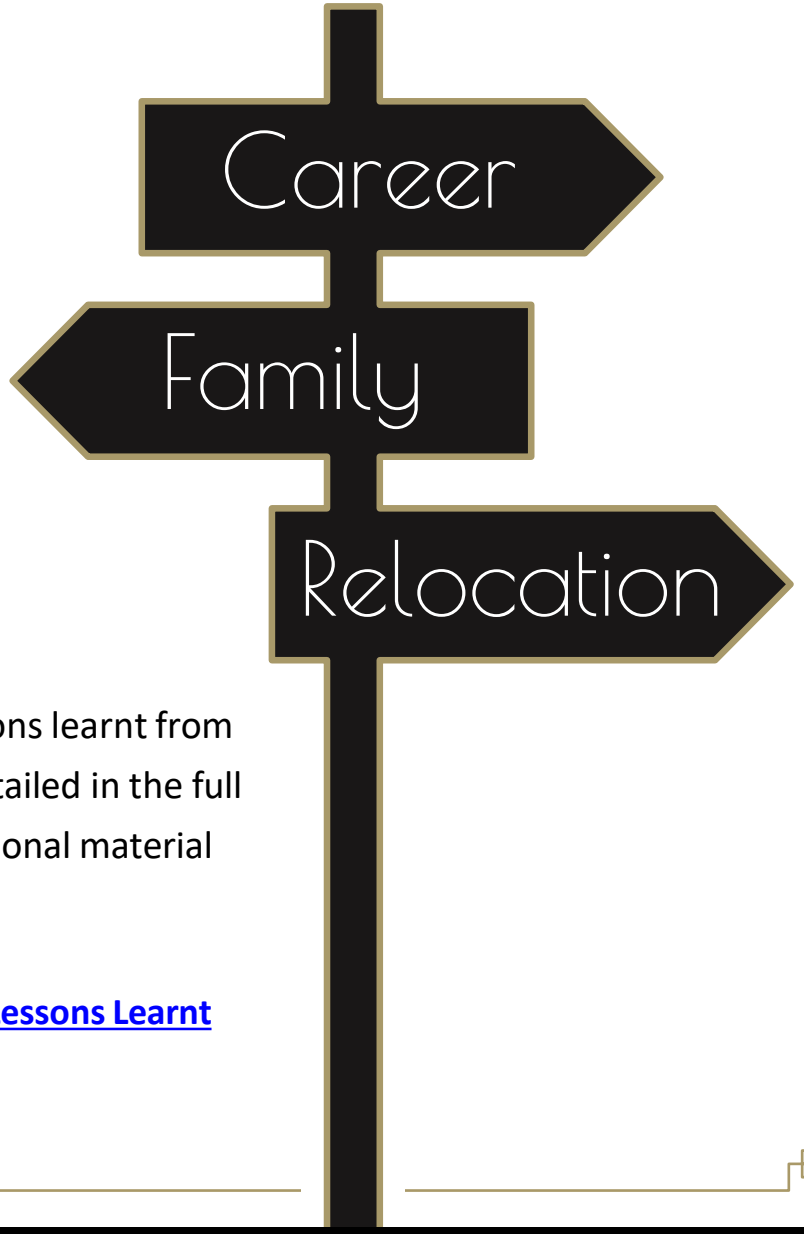




RESPOND

Poor Engagement

Lessons Learnt from Resignations



Loss of members from your Unit will invariably be disappointing. Whilst we would hope that the reason individuals leave is shared with the Unit in many cases the reason stated does not match that which was the main / final reason the exit came.

Provinces that operate Retrieval Teams are able to work impartially with members on their exit from Units. The hope is that with engagement, the member may relocate to another Unit or, at minimum, leave Freemasonry with a more positive outlook on the organisation that they may have had.

When you experience resignations as a unit, you can contact your **Provincial Team** and ask for guidance and support. They may well be able to assist you in an impartial review. However, if you feel able as a unit, this can be done by yourselves.

Guidance on lessons learnt from resignations is detailed in the full thread with additional material signposted:

Thread Link: Lessons Learnt from Resignations



RESPOND

Poor Engagement

Recognising the need to review

Recognising the need to review your Unit is crucial in ensuring its relevance, sustainability, and value to members. Whilst reviews can be scheduled, sometimes circumstances dictate when you should start a review.

When reviewing your Unit, using the threads in the Shape Hub [supported by material in the other hubs], members should ensure that discussions remain focused on activities and roles and not individuals within the Unit. Occasionally, having someone who is not a member of the Unit as a meeting facilitator can ensure a balanced discussion and if concerns develop, can help the Unit seek assistance from the Province to address any concerns which may relate to individuals.

Specific guidance on the steps to consider in the review are listed in the full thread and include:

1. Declining membership numbers
2. Member engagement being low
3. Outdated offerings
4. Lack of Clear Value Proposition
5. Poor feedback or Member Complaints
6. Internal Challenges

Recognising the need to review your Unit is crucial in ensuring its relevance

Thread Link:



RESPOND

Alternative Futures

Unit Options

Traditionally, a Unit that struggles to engage an active membership and secure enough members attending to be quorate will eventually drift to closure (operating until no longer viable is an option if that is what members want). This does not have to be the case, should members wish to embrace change.

The most common options are summarised below:

Items of good practice will be added over time; in the meantime, any member wishing to discuss the options below should contact their Provincial Membership Team.

1. Working with the Provincial Membership Team to reinvigorate the Unit
2. Re-purposing as a Special Interest Lodge or Chapter
3. Looking to Merge with another Lodge or Chapter
4. Relocation of the Unit to another Masonic Jurisdiction
5. Staged Closure

These five options are reviewed in more detail in the full thread and in the support material a model of good practice for closure of a Unit is outlined.

Thread Link: Unit Options

CLICK PDF icon to download the support material

Good Practice Surrender of a Warrant or Charter by a Unit



RESPOND

Alternative Futures

Creating Efficiencies in a Unit

Traditions are embedded within our organisation and meetings however on occasion some traditions must evolve to meet the changing needs of the membership.

Changes in working practices, family and economic pressures have changed with the Pandemic switching many people to hybrid or remote working.

When looking at options for efficiencies in your Unit any changes should be balanced with maintaining enjoyment and dignity associated with a meeting.

Suggested options of creating efficiencies during and after the meeting are detailed in the full thread, examples include:

1. Sing the opening and closing odes during any procession into and recession out of the Lodge / Chapter,
2. Adjust start and finish times to be convenient for current members and likely applicants
3. Circulate minutes in advance of the meeting, rather than reading them and after the meeting
4. Consider whether meals with many courses are always wanted or whether two would suffice
5. Encourage all speakers to be brief but not perfunctory
6. Aim to conclude formal proceedings of the Festive Board within an agreed time so members who need to leave can do so 'without feeling guilty'

Thread Link: Creating Efficiencies in a Unit

CLICK PDF icon to download the support material

Case study
Savage Club Chapter

UNITED GRAND LODGE OF ENGLAND

BUILDING TOGETHER

SUPREME GRAND CHAPTER OF ROYAL ARCH MASONS OF ENGLAND



Engage
For Provincial L&D and Mentoring Leads

Agenda

- Strategic Update
- Membership Challenge
- Solomon Updates
- Building Together
  - Focus on Mentoring and L&D

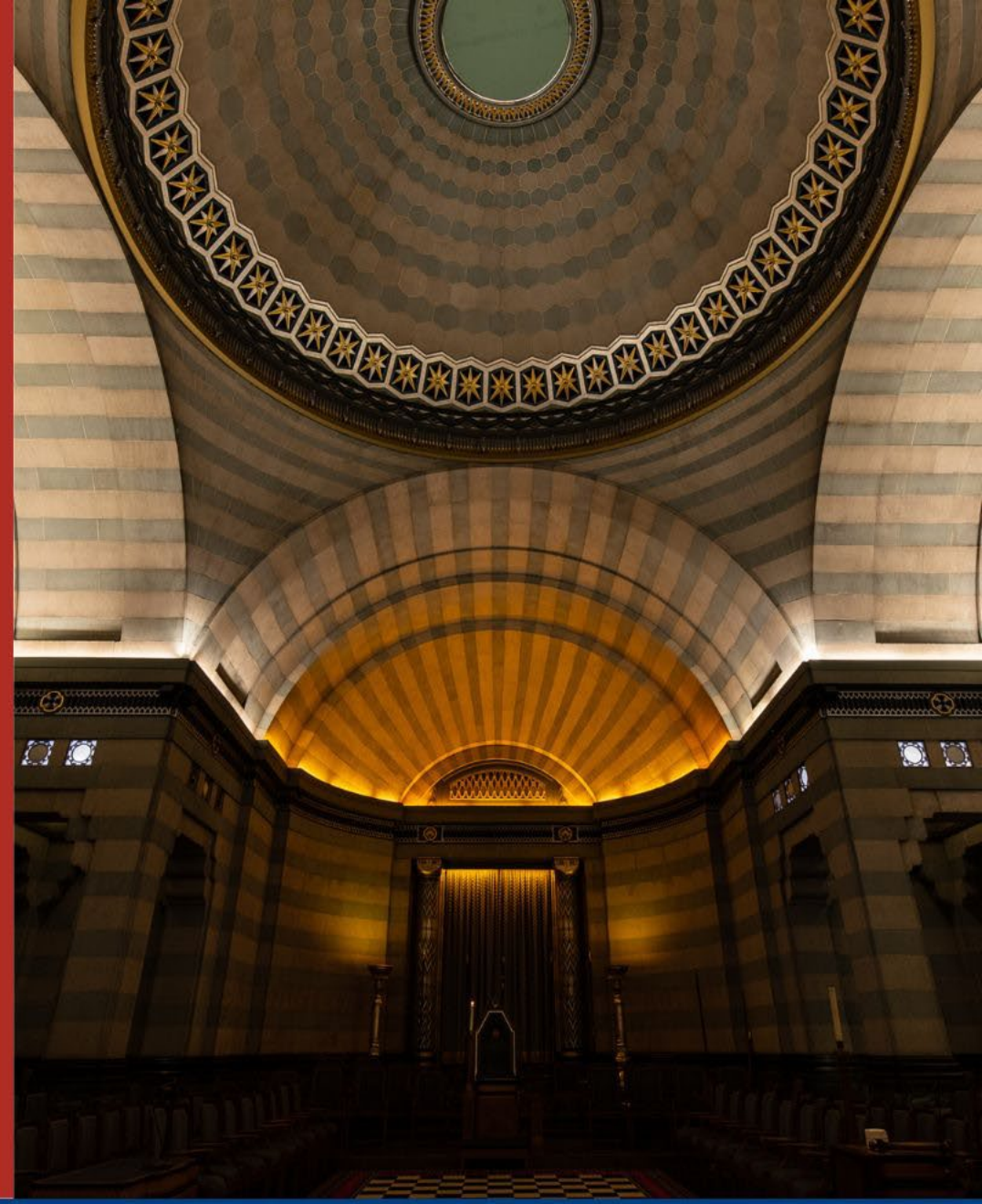
Membership – Engage Hub

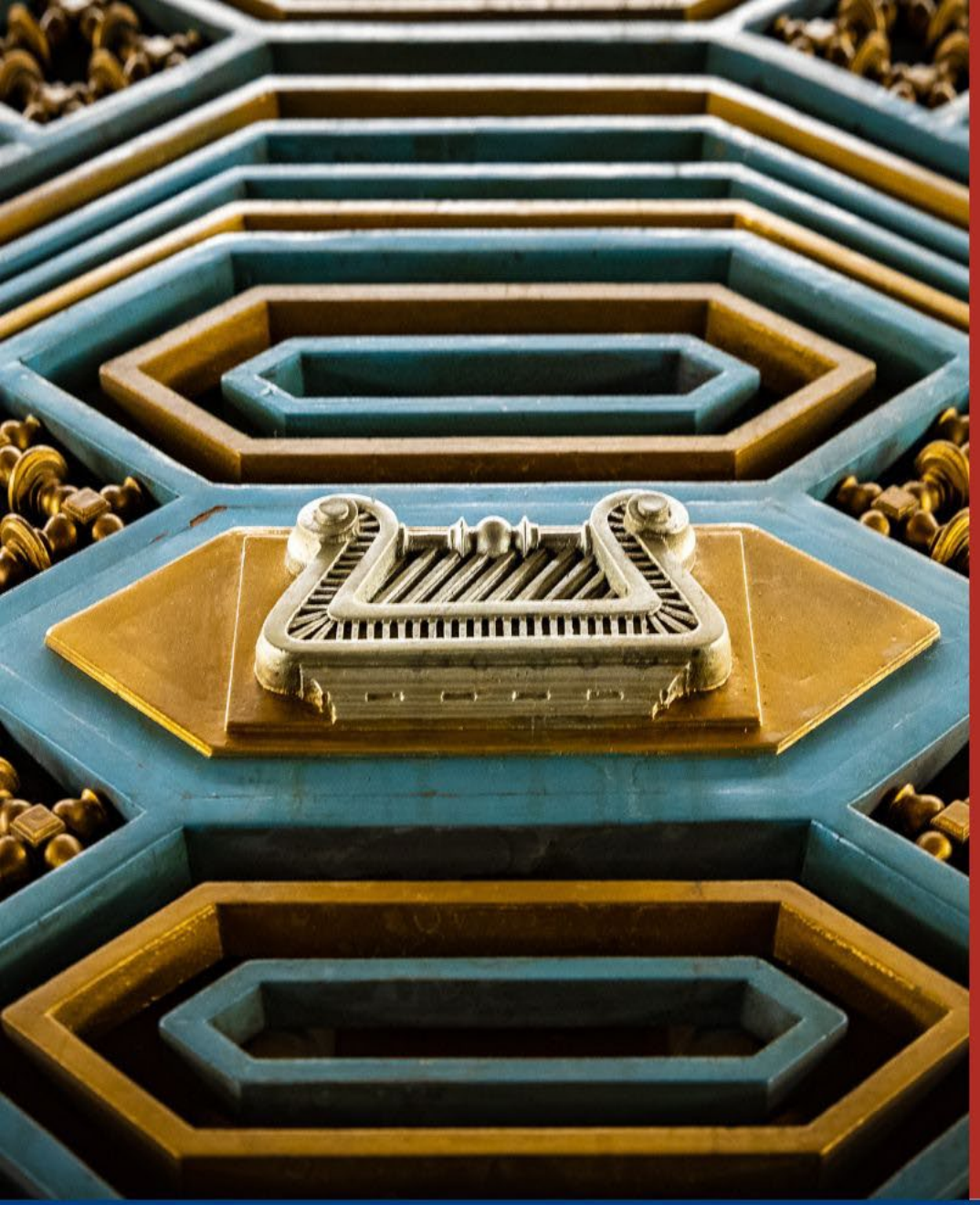
Building Together Delivery Group (BTDG) – **Technical Advisory Groups (TAGs)**

Small teams of with relevant expertise and/or professional knowledge to provide content, especially the in-depth training resources, to help Provinces embed Building Together.

Team Leaders

- **Mentoring – Lead W.Bro Graham Chisnell**
  (experienced Headteacher, Schools' Inspector, author and learning needs specialist)
- **Learning and Development – W. Bro Professor Edward Rochead**
  (member of the L&D Programme Board, Professor of Innovation Strategy)
- **Migration and Retrieval – W. Bro Nick Thomas**
  (Deputy Chairman of Universities Scheme Compliance and Audit Specialist)





Membership – Engage Hub

Mentoring

- **Engaging both new and established Members** (Brethren and Companions)
- **Embed understanding:** Active Mentoring process is important, not just for new members.
- **Encourage their development**, strengthen the Lodge / Chapter helping to deter avoidable resignations.
- **Lodge Mentors and a Brother's personal mentor** are the best individuals to **signpost continuing their journey into the Royal Arch**
- Knowledge, understanding, involvement and enjoyment are all Important in ensuring that members maintain their interest and commitment to Freemasonry and to their Lodge & Chapter.

Good Mentoring = Conversations NOT a series of emails

Membership – Engage Hub

Migration & Retrieval

Migration

- Good Practice documents and included in the Provincial and Unit Guides for Building Together
- Training and support are available to Provincial Teams
- MWP Migration Group still leading this area and BTDG TAG providing support

Retrieval

- Craft and Royal Arch Team training now available from BTDG Technical Advisory Group Members



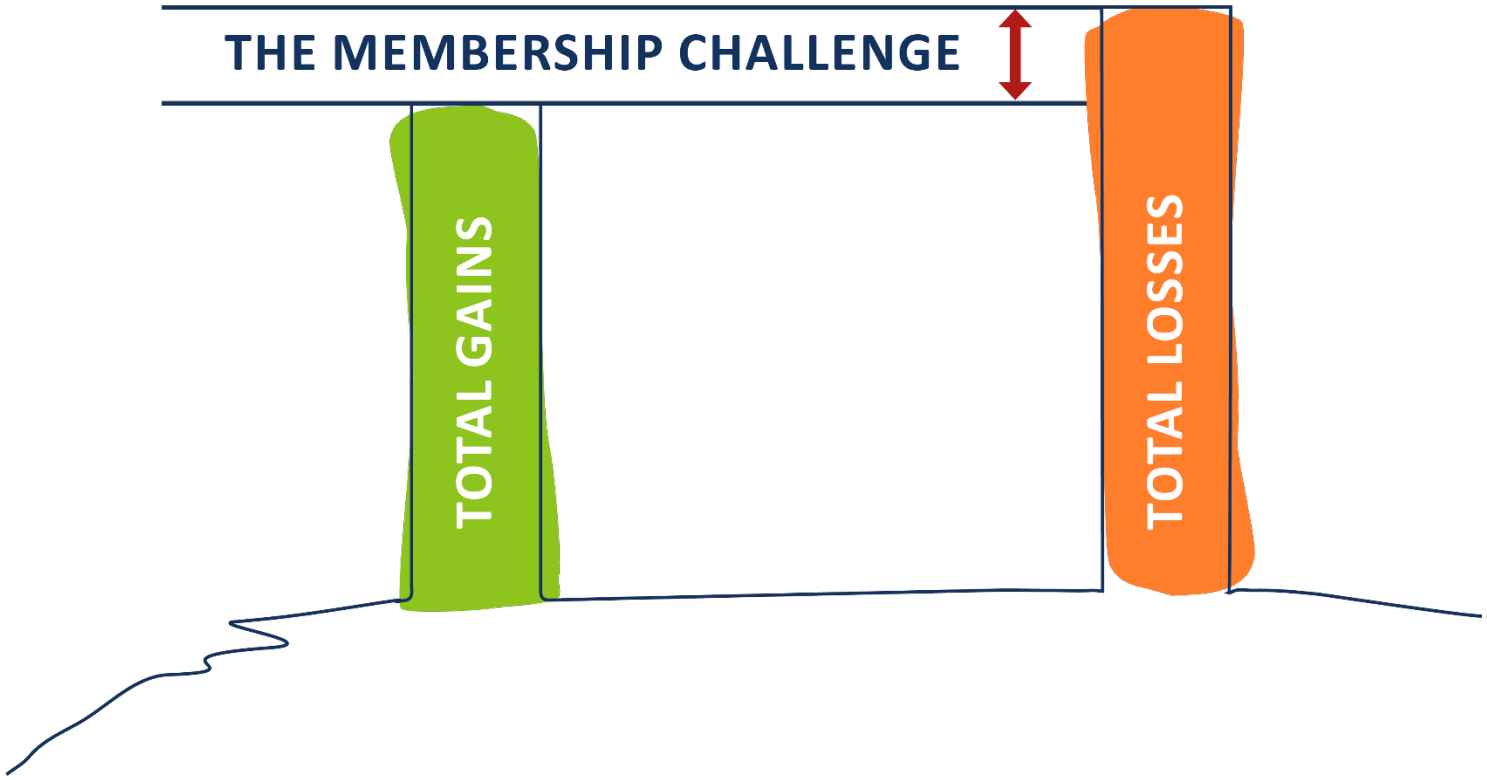


Membership – Engage Hub

Light Blues Clubs

- Paper drafted for the establishment of national Light Blues Committee
- Due for approval (MWP) and implementation Summer 2025
- Each RCG will have a Light Blue Representative

Membership Challenge



Building Together

- Harmonises Archway and Members' Pathway
  - Will include Provincial level material
- Has rescoped the Engage Hub from Members' Pathway
  - Now includes unit level retrieve activities
- Focus on unit level activities responding to Right Hand Side of the Membership Challenge

Solomon Update

- Go to Demo
  - Including Solomon Lives
  - Solomon-GPT
  - Solomon Academy
    - Testing and Proving Your Daily Advancement in Masonic Knowledge | United Grand Lodge of England

Mentoring and L&D

- Working together
  - In Lodges (and soon Chapters) the Mentor covers both areas
- Focussing on:
  - Supporting the New Member
  - Continued Support (to more experienced Members)
- Working with the Provincial Almoner
- Priority
  - Supporting units to ‘engage’ their members, so they actually want to attend and remain a member. *Or help them find a better unit for them.*

Training for Mentoring and L&D Leads

- Planned:
  - Online Overview of Engage
  - Online Training for:
    - Unit Mentors
    - Personal Mentors
    - Provincial Mentors and L&D Leads

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Mentoring





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Thread Link: Fostering Fun, Enjoyment and Satisfaction

CLICK PDF icon to download the support material

PDF Getting More Out of The Royal Arch

PDF Readings During Exaltations and Installation

Learning condition guide for freemasons

Harness your superpower

Home

1

Dyslexia

Words on a page may be easy for some but for others it may be daunting.

2

Autism

Delivery of ritual can come as second nature for some.

3

Attention Deficit and Hyperactivity Disorder

Keeping focus when learning ritual or in the temple can seem easy for some.



How to navigate this guide

Move from page to page to read the whole document.
Click on any underlined text to jump to a page.
Click Home below the East Kent Province Logo to return here.



Learning Conditions

- General principles for inclusive ritual learning:
- Provide advance notice of any ritual to be learned—several months ahead if possible.
- Offer a choice of learning methods (listening, reading, acting out) so brethren can use what works best for them.
- Encourage short, regular practice sessions over long, infrequent ones.
- Pair brethren with a supportive mentor who understands their learning style.
- Create an environment where mistakes are part of the learning journey, not something to fear.

Equip Provincial L & D Officers with the necessary tools to carry out their roles



What will be in the Toolbox?



Promote Solomon 80%



Promote Solomon	80%
Mentor integration	80%



Promote Solomon	80%
Mentor integration	80%
Strategy preparation	70%



Promote Solomon	80%
Mentor integration	80%
Strategy preparation	70%
The Training Cycle	70%



Promote Solomon	80%
Mentor integration	80%
Strategy preparation	70%
The Training Cycle	70%
L&DO support	70%



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Mentor integration	80%
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L&DO support	70%
Team building	60%



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Mentor integration	80%
Strategy preparation	70%
The Training Cycle	70%
L&DO support	70%
Team building	60%
Evaluation	60%



Training for Mentoring and L&D Leads

- What else?